BRANDON RUIZ

Systems Engineer — Windows Server · Active Directory · Linux · VMware · FortiGate Networking · PowerShell · Microsoft 365 / Defender

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SUMMARY

Systems engineer who works across both platforms end to end: Windows Server 2022, Active Directory, DNS and file services on VMware ESXi 8.0.3 and vCenter, plus a 79-service Ubuntu 24.04 fleet administered entirely from the command line. Also configures and troubleshoots the network underneath them — FortiGate 60F dual-WAN SD-WAN, DHCP, NTP, authoritative DNS rebuilds, SSL-VPN and physical-layer work in inherited Cisco/TRENDnet PoE racks. Automates in PowerShell, documents what he builds (25-document operations package, 4-phase incident-response runbook, topology and IP-scheme drawings), and builds audit-and-hardening tooling mapped to written baselines, validated on a test workstation with before/after output and full transcripts. In IT since 2016; full-time systems engineering since 2025.

CORE SKILLS

Networking and layer 1: FortiGate 60F (dual-WAN SD-WAN, SSL-VPN/FortiClient, web filtering with SSL inspection, NTP, DHCP, CLI diagnostics); authoritative DNS migration with full A/CNAME/MX/TXT/SRV rebuilds, SPF/DKIM/DMARC and TTL staging; Test-Connection/Resolve-DnsName sweeps; physical-layer troubleshooting in inherited Cisco ASA/ISR/ASR/Catalyst and TRENDnet PoE racks; SIP/ALG VoIP diagnostics; IP scheme and topology documentation

Linux and automation: Ubuntu 24.04 (Hetzner), systemd services and timers, ufw/iptables default-deny, WireGuard split tunnels and policy routing, journald/rsyslog/logrotate tuning, OpenSSH key hygiene, Docker Compose, Caddy TLS, rclone, Postgres; PowerShell advanced functions (CmdletBinding/ShouldProcess), transcripts, CSV/JSON reporting, audit and remediation tooling

Windows, identity and virtualization: Windows Server 2022 AD DS, DNS and file services; user/OU/group provisioning; GPO software and certificate deployment; Entra hybrid join (dsregcmd, Service Connection Point); DC time service and Kerberos remediation; privileged-credential handover and rotation; least-privilege and break-glass admin design; Windows 10/11 fleets, USMT migrations, WinRE/DISM/SFC repair, Event Log and WMI diagnostics; VMware ESXi 8.0.3 and vCenter, Dell PowerEdge T350 with iDRAC, N-able RMM

Security, backup and documentation: Defender for Endpoint and Defender for Office 365, Bitdefender GravityZone migration, CVE triage to CVSS 9.8, third-Saturday patch window and 95% compliance target, hardening baselines (secedit password/lockout, BitLocker, Windows Firewall with Advanced Security, SMBv1 and RDP/NLA controls), HIPAA 45 CFR 164-mapped audit toolkit, PCI DSS SAQ, security policy and incident-response runbook; Veeam Backup & Replication 12.1, Backblaze B2 and Amazon S3 with Object Lock, Wasabi immutable repositories, Synology NAS SMB repositories, backup-copy jobs, GFS retention, restore tests, RTO tiers; Microsoft 365 Business Premium as CSP, Exchange Online mail flow, Secure Score baselining

PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

LB Computer Help · Systems Engineer / Owner

Feb 2025 – Present

Long Beach / Anaheim, CA

Sole engineer for SMB Windows Server, Active Directory, Linux, Microsoft 365, backup, network and endpoint environments under signed MSAs with defined SLAs.

- Resolved a full VoIP and internet outage for an 8-workstation office by tracing SIP registration failures to router ALG/SPI interference in a rack of Cisco ASA 5510, ISR 2811/2911, ASR 901 and Catalyst 2960/TRENDnet PoE switching; corrected consumer routers serving DHCP in place of the enterprise gear.
- Repaired Windows 11 upgrade and boot failures with DISM, SFC and bootrec; onboarded endpoints to Defender for Endpoint for a client tenant; configured M365 DNS zones (MX, SPF, DKIM, DMARC, autodiscover, SRV) for additional client domains; deployed Synology NAS and Dell OptiPlex workstations with Defender for a medical office.
- Wrote a 646-line HIPAA-mapped (45 CFR 164) Windows audit-and-remediation module in PowerShell (CmdletBinding/ShouldProcess): audits BitLocker, firewall profiles, Defender state, RDP/NLA, SMBv1, local Administrators, patch recency and screen-lock policy, applies a secedit password/lockout baseline and emits per-host JSON/CSV evidence; validated end to end on a test workstation with before/after output and full transcripts.

Key engagement — 7-user marine-services client (managed services + migration project), Mar – Aug 2025. Windows Server 2022 DC and file server plus an Ubuntu VM on VMware ESXi 8.0.3 (Dell PowerEdge T350, iDRAC, vCenter); FortiGate 60F dual-WAN SD-WAN; Synology NAS; M365 Business Premium; Veeam B&R; N-able RMM.

- Built the domain-profile firewall rule set for an inherited DC in PowerShell: audited the 22 inbound ports the DC, Veeam and RMM roles require, found four already covered by built-in rules and created inbound rules for the rest with NetSecurity cmdlets, then swept all 8 workstations with Resolve-DnsName and Test-Connection before pushing the RMM agent by GPO with remote Invoke-GPUpdate.
- Root-caused domain-wide Group Policy and Kerberos failures to a free-running DC clock: reconfigured w32tm on the DC and the FortiGate NTP source, then verified machine trust and policy application with nltest and gpupdate.

- Diagnosed failed Entra hybrid device registration (dsregcmd "AD Configuration Test: FAIL 0x80070002") to a missing Azure AD Service Connection Point and created it on the DC in PowerShell (New-ADObject under CN=Configuration), restoring device registration and Defender for Endpoint onboarding.
- Migrated authoritative DNS from Rackspace to GoDaddy and cut mail from ProofPoint to Exchange Online: staged TTLs to 300 s, rebuilt the record set, implemented SPF/DKIM/DMARC (p=quarantine), resolved a next-day inbound issue from message traces, verified the live zone by export.
- Documented the FortiGate dual-WAN SD-WAN from live CLI diagnostics; set up FortiClient SSL-VPN and iDRAC remote access; replaced Cisco Umbrella with FortiGate web filtering plus SSL inspection, CA distributed by GPO.
- Took over the environment from a national MSP on a two-week deadline: inventoried and re-secured ~20 privileged accounts (Domain Admin, ESXi root, iDRAC, vCenter, FortiGate, NAS, switch, CSP global admin), negotiated global-admin handover from an MFA-locked incumbent account, removed plaintext credentials from inherited runbooks, created a documented break-glass admin, scoped single-bucket backup keys and set a semi-annual rotation policy.
- Replaced Bitdefender GravityZone with Defender for Endpoint on the server and 8 workstations and ProofPoint with Defender for Office 365 (validated with EICAR and phishing tests); owned the tenant's Defender vulnerability notifications for the engagement, triaging ~30 CVE alerts against a third-Saturday patch window and a 95% compliance target — including CVE-2025-47981 (Windows SPNEGO, CVSS 9.8, 8 exposed devices, notified 8 Jul 2025), routed to that month's window.
- Re-platformed Veeam backups for the DC and file server off the incumbent's cloud vault to immutable object storage (Backblaze B2 with 30-day Object Lock, then Wasabi with GFS 12/4/7), specified the Advanced license the client purchased, ran restore tests, defined RTO tiers (4 h DC/file server, 8 h, 24 h) and troubleshot production backup-copy failures.
- Authored the security policy, a 4-phase incident-response runbook and a 25-document operations package (backup, M365, topology and IP scheme, security configuration, support references, user training) with AD onboarding/offboarding by OU and group and GPO MSI deployment SOPs; upgraded the tenant to Business Premium via CSP with no user disruption and baselined Secure Score (45 → 70 target); migrated a domain workstation to Windows 11 with USMT after resolving an Entra-join conflict; supported a PCI DSS SAQ by identifying the payment terminal from its USB vendor/product IDs and drafting the questionnaire entries.

Non-IT roles · **Operations and logistics** 2018 – 2024

- Worked outside IT while studying infrastructure independently; returned to IT full-time in 2025.

Geeks-On-Site · **IT Specialist (field)** Jun – Oct 2021

- Residential and small-business break-fix, malware removal, connectivity and data recovery.

Fusion Contact Centers · **IT Support Technician → Escalation (Advanced Call Quality) Team** Aug 2016 – Aug 2017
Reno, NV

- Promoted to the escalation team for tier 2/3 tickets: help desk, password resets, workstation support and documentation of standard fixes; WAN connectivity troubleshooting and customer firewall rule requests; 8x8 VoIP "phones down" outages, SIP registration and QoS diagnostics.

Early technical background · **XDA Developers** 2013 – 2014

- Published the N.E.O.N. custom Android ROM for the Verizon Galaxy Note 3 on XDA Developers as *Brandonrz*.

EDUCATION & CERTIFICATIONS

No formal degree; self-taught in IT since 2016. Self-directed study: Microsoft Learn (SC-900, AZ-800), CompTIA Security+ objectives, Veeam and Fortinet documentation.

SELECTED INFRASTRUCTURE PROJECTS (SELF-MANAGED LINUX FLEET, 2026)

- **Fleet security hardening and incident response:** audited a 79-service systemd fleet, found no host firewall in front of 6 internet-facing services, enabled ufw default-deny and proved it by external probe; added authentication to two exposed dashboards (401/200 verified); ran incident response on a credential exposed in a public repo for ~4 months — purged it from the repository's full history with git-filter-repo and force-pushed, verified zero commits remained, re-issued 7 API keys, confirmed the old key returned 401 and swept every repo.
- **Traffic engineering and automation:** policy-routing split tunnel (iptables fwmark, ip rule/route, IPv6 reject) as a systemd service around WireGuard, with Google routes computed as announced ranges minus GCP space (22.2 M → 1.09 M addresses, TTFB 1.2–3.3 s → 0.21–0.48 s); Docker Compose stack (Postgres 16, n8n, Caddy) exposing only 443 with automatic TLS; dashboard payload cut 570 KB → 56–64 KB (HTTP/1.1 keep-alive + gzip).
- **Storage engineering and backups:** grew a dual-boot root partition 61.5 → 132.6 GiB with an initramfs pre-mount script gated by an ntfsresize dry run and a SHA-256 check before rewriting the partition table; root-caused runaway /var/log growth to 1.4 M AppArmor audit denials and cut ~800 MB/rotation to 0 MB/h with rsyslog, journald and logrotate caps; off-site rclone snapshots with SHA-256 restore checks.